

Map your dreams

We spoke to Himanshu Goyal, Country Manager, Academic & Developer Relations of Career Education & Localisation at IBM. He shared insights on academic initiatives. Excerpts...

Nash David

nash.david@thinkdigit.com

d What are the various activities initiated by IBM developerWorks?

Through developerWorks, we constantly look at engaging developers and encouraging them to try their hands at IBM software. For instance, the IBM Developer Superstar contest challenged Indian developers to conceptualise smart application ideas and build a prototype using IBM software.

Our pan-India road show last year, Develothon, attracted a large following. Over 40 days, our software and technical experts conducted briefings and lectures at various engineering colleges and cities for the developer audience on emerging technologies such as cloud computing, business intelligence, mash-ups, collaborative solutions etc.

The developerWorks platform itself (ibm.com/developerWorks) is probably the most extensive resource you'd find on IBM software and open technologies, providing in-depth technical know-how coupled with the advantages of a social network in My developerWorks (ibm.com/developerWorks/mydeveloperworks).

d How good do you think the Indian education system is?

Our education system is definitely one of the best in the world. Sure, there's always room for improvement, but the emphasis on the basic building blocks in our education system serves as a very good starting point for anyone.

What our system lacks however – and I find this specific to the IT industry – is the lack of experiential learning coupled with functional competencies. For instance, if you were to look at career paths for professionals such as academicians or doctors, you'd find each step very struc-



Himanshu Goyal, Country Manager, Academic & Developer Relations, Career Education & Localisation, IBM Software India/South Asia

tured, in terms of defined education paths and experiential learning. In contrast, if we look at Computer Science and Engineering, the unfortunate reality is that by the end of the final year, the student is only looking at getting a job but is still unclear of the area of specialisation due to the surfeit of career options thereafter.

Our solution to this lacuna is the IBM Career Education Program (ibm.com/in/careereducation). This programme checks the basic skill areas of the candidate in three basic strengths: whether he is an observer, planner or doer. We further broaden this to relate these key strength areas to disciplines of Quality, Manager and Engineering. We then provide detailed career paths to the young professionals and help them gain all the relevant skills, complete an IBM-certified project and make themselves adept with largely used IBM products. They're equipped with the knowledge to serve some of the largest enterprise businesses. This programme brings together the latest software

content, real-world industry experience, hands-on lab courses and best practices to a single unique education platform.

d Any advice to budding software engineers/ developers on picking a career opportunity? What factors should they consider?

My advice would be to build on your strengths and inherent skills. The beauty of the IT industry is that there are a plethora of career choices available, each of which provide you the flexibility to build on your strengths and interests, yet help you reach the role that you desire. For instance, a person skilled in conceiving, designing and creating applications could look at the career paths for Software Engineers (or *Doers* as we call them) which would lead them to the role of a Principal Engineer or a Solution Architect or an Information Architect, etc., while someone who has a keen eye for detail, or for reviewing things and adding value to make them should look at the career paths for a Quality Analyst (or *Observer*), while someone who excels at co-ordinating, managing people and projects, and juggling multiple stakeholders, could look at the career paths for a *Planner* and hence build their career in the Management function. Within each such broad career or skill options we see multiple career paths that could cater to different platforms and technologies, for instance developing embedded applications for mobile phones, ATMs, etc., enterprise applications using Java/ J2EE, etc.

d Could you sum up IBM's 100 years?

Over the last 100 years, IBM has constantly redefined innovation – think about the barcode, fractal geometry or the first computer to beat the reigning champion at chess, the list is endless. Innovation, that has allowed Information Technology to solve real-world problems. Along the way, IBM has also broken many social barriers, be it our first woman vice president in 1943, or hiring Michael Supa, a blind psychologist in 1942. One thing I can be sure of – the next century will be even more exciting than the one that went by. **d**